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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



GOP Sen. Chuck Grassley, left, chair of the Senate Judiciary Committee, listens as Sen. Dick Durbin, the panel's top Democrat, questions Kash Patel, President Donald Trump's pick to lead the FBI, during his confirmation hearing before the committee on Thursday.
 ANNA MONEYMAKER/GETTY

Durbin on the front lines

Longtime US senator's latest role: Leading Democratic opposition to Trump's controversial nominees

By Daniel C. Vock | Chicago Tribune

WASHINGTON —

With dark-rimmed glasses balanced in the middle of his nose as he looked down on the man President Donald Trump wants to run the FBI, Illinois' senior senator spoke uninterrupted for 13 minutes late last week as stone-faced nominee Kash Patel shifted in his seat.

"Mr. Patel has neither the experience, the temperament, nor the judgment to lead an agency of 38,000 (agents) and 400 field offices around the globe," U.S. Sen. Dick Durbin said in his opening statement for Patel's Senate Judiciary Committee confirmation hearing Thursday. "During the time I've served on this committee, I've had the opportunity to consider four FBI director nominations. Each one was a Republican. And I voted for all of them. My concerns about the director of the FBI are not partisan."

While Durbin argued that he wasn't picking on Patel because he's a Republican, his comments blasting Trump's pick also weren't a wholly unusual position for the Senate's No. 2 Democrat.

Indeed, Durbin now finds himself on the front lines of the opposition party's response to Trump's ambitious efforts to turn the federal government upside down. That's especially true when it comes to matters of the judiciary and the rule of law, and it could mean Durbin one day will be the top Democrat questioning — and probably opposing — any Trump picks for the U.S. Supreme Court.

Durbin was always likely to be a frequent Trump critic on the Judiciary Committee. But with Republicans taking control of the Senate this past election, his job will be even more focused on rallying opposition as the panel's top Democrat.

The Republican president, who faced federal criminal investiga-

tions for interfering with elections and stealing classified documents, has begun to install people personally loyal to him to lead the Justice Department and the FBI. Trump also fired career DOJ lawyers who worked with a special prosecutor on Trump-related investigations.

Since Trump named the nominees in November, Durbin has hammered Patel for repeatedly touting conspiracy theories and threatening to go after Trump's enemies and questioned whether Pam Bondi, the former Florida attorney general who represented Trump during his first impeachment trial, would act independently of the president as the nation's attorney general. Nevertheless, her confirmation passed through the committee in a party-line vote.

In cable news interviews, Durbin has railed against Trump's pardon of violent Jan. 6 protesters

Turn to Durbin, Page 2

Trump: Tariffs to bring 'pain'

US prices may rise in trade war with Canada, Mexico

By Josh Boak
Associated Press

PALM BEACH, Fla. — Americans could feel "some pain" from the emerging trade war triggered by his tariffs against Canada, Mexico and China, President Donald Trump said Sunday, claiming Canada would "cease to exist" without its trade surplus with the United States.

The trade penalties that Trump signed Saturday at his Florida resort caused a mix of panic, anger and uncertainty, and threatened to rupture a decades-old partnership on trade in North America while straining relations with China.

"Canadians are perplexed," said Kirsten Hillman, the country's ambassador to the U.S. "We view ourselves as your neighbor, your closest friend, your ally."

By following through on a campaign pledge, Trump may also have simultaneously broken his promise to voters in last year's election that his administration could quickly reduce inflation. That means the same frustration he is facing from other nations might also spread domestically to consumers and businesses.

"WILL THERE BE SOME PAIN? YES, MAYBE (AND MAYBE NOT!)," Trump said in a social media post. "BUT WE WILL MAKE AMERICA GREAT AGAIN, AND IT WILL ALL BE WORTH THE PRICE THAT MUST BE PAID."

He has not said how high that price could be or what improvements would need to be seen in stopping illegal immigration and the smuggling of fentanyl to merit the removal of the tariffs that Trump imposed under the justification of an economic

Turn to Tariffs, Page 9

Pritzker faces challenge to show that 'Illinois can govern itself'

Growing deficit projections hang over city's budget season

By Olivia Olander,
Jeremy Gorner
and Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — With Gov. JB Pritzker still weighing whether to seek a third term, the firmer foundation he's laid for Illinois' historically shaky finances faces a major stress test from ballooning deficit projections, increased spending pressures and uncertainty over

federal assistance with President Donald Trump back in the White House.

Ahead of his Feb. 19 budget speech, Pritzker is staring down a hole that his administration pegged in November at more than \$3 billion, a gap expected only to widen in future years if Pritzker and his Democratic allies in the legislature don't take steps to rein in spending or raise taxes. It could prove to be a legacy-defining moment for a politically ambitious governor who has made strong fiscal stewardship a cornerstone of his identity, even as the state's operating budget has grown by nearly a

third during his tenure, to \$53.1 billion. (Adjusting for recent high inflation, the increase is a more modest 8%.)

The challenges Pritzker faces are myriad: mandated increases in funding for schools and pensions; a negligible increase in revenue; a misstep in previous tax disbursements; and ambitious health care funding plans coupled with rising medical costs.

There will also be pressure for new spending, including requests from Chicago for help fixing longstanding financial problems

Turn to Budget, Page 4



Less chilly, per Willie

Woodstock Willie is held by his owner, Mark Szafran, as "Groundhog Day" actor Stephen Tobolowsky looks on Sunday after reading the prognostication for spring at Groundhog Days in Woodstock Square. Willie the groundhog did not see his shadow, which according to lore means spring will come early this year. Willie is just 8 months old.

STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Graduate student unions gear up to protect gains under 2nd Trump term

By Carolyn Stein
Chicago Tribune

Andy Archer did not know what was going to come first: a raise from a new union contract or the birth of his first child.

The third-year doctoral student had spent months bargaining with his employer — the University of Chicago — on everything from increasing pay for research and teaching

assistants to expanding health care benefits. Archer had been involved in other organizing efforts before, but bargaining for his graduate student union he said was "one of the most thrilling projects" he'd ever been a part of.

But then, in March 2024, the union reached an agreement with the university. For Archer, that meant a stipend increase from about \$33,000 in 2023

to \$45,000 in 2024, with a 3% increase each year for the next two years, he said.

And the contract came just in time for Archer — right before ratification, his son was born.

"I finally felt like I was at a stable enough point in my life where I had enough job security and had a stable enough wage that I could have a kid and start a

Turn to Unions, Page 3

INSIDE

Families visit site of helicopter-jet crash in DC

Divers scoured the submerged wreckage in the Potomac River for more remains after authorities said they've recovered 55 of the 67 people killed. **Nation & World**

Oldest former Chicago Bear dies at 95 in Indiana

Gene Schroeder, a two-time Pro Bowler who was drafted by the Bears in 1951 and spent six years as a wide receiver, "just led a really incredible life," his daughter said. **Chicago Sports**

